Nimra Asif

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Research Areas

Areas of Specialization: Philosophy of Mind, Animal Minds
Areas of Competence: Cognitive Science, Applied Ethics, Philosophy of Language

Education

August, 2026 **Ph.D. in Philosophy**, University of Connecticut.
Dissertation Title: *Minimal Mindreading: A Millikanian Approach*
Committee: Dorit Bar-On (advisor), William Lycan, Lionel Shapiro, Richard Moore (external reader)
This dissertation develops an account of a form of mindreading that those with limited or still developing cognitive resources, such as nonhuman animals and infants, can plausibly use to understand others. Drawing on the teleosemantic framework, especially the notion of pushmi-pullyu representations (Millikan, 1984, 2017), I develop an account on which minimal mindreaders represent others' mental states as affordances, recognizing and responding to them noninferentially, without concepts or mental state attribution. I argue that this account carves out a genuine middle ground between full-blown mindreading and behavior-reading by making the process of mindreading (the 'how') easier for minimal mindreaders.

May, 2026 **Graduate Certificate in College Instruction**, University of Connecticut.

Graduate Certificate in Cognitive Science, University of Connecticut.

May, 2021 **M.A. in Philosophy**, University of Connecticut.

June, 2018 **B.A. in Philosophy**, Brooklyn College, City University of New York.
Summa Cum Laude.

Research Publications

Journal Articles

1. Asif, N. (2022). "Minimal theory of mind – a Millikanian approach." *Synthese*, *200*(2), Article 150. https://doi.org/10.1007/s11229-022-03662-6

Papers Under Review

1. "Pushmi-pullyu Representations: What They Are and Why They Matter," *under review*; draft available upon request.
Pushmi-pullyu representations, introduced by Millikan, describe the world and direct an organism's response to it at the same time. Recently, some authors have raised doubts about the coherence and usefulness of such representations. This paper argues that, on the contrary, they form a distinctive and theoretically sound class of representations. It shows how they can help explain non-human animal behavior, communication, and social cognition, as well as human behavior.

2. "Detached Factic Thought" (with Drew Johnson), *under review*; draft available upon request.
The capacity to represent situations far removed from immediately perceptible environments and current motivations appears to be integral to human cognition and language. This paper proposes a hypothesis about the natural origins of this capacity for detached factic thought. It distinguishes three forms of detachment: environmental, referential, and practical. It also puts forward another distinction that cuts across these: between degreed and full detachment, since mental representations can be more or less detached from the current environment and the situation they represent and more or less relevant to current needs and motivations. We argue that attention plays a key role in all of these forms of detachment. Attention and detachment emerge together, but it is the organizing work of attention that makes detachment possible.

Research Experience

Spring 2026 **Graduate Certificate in Cognitive Science**, University of Connecticut.
Completed seminars across psychology, linguistics, and neuroscience on how the mind works and how people think, learn, and act. Wrote research papers and gave presentations on competing theories of learning, developmental research on learning, and work on language and theory of mind development in children.

Fall 2022 – Spring 2024 **Research Assistant**, Compass Ethics
Conducted background research on the ethics of artificial intelligence and emerging technologies, as well as bioethics, for the consultancy's papers and grant proposals. Identified and pursued research funding for its AI and technology ethics work, and supported focus group sessions with client organizations.

Fall 2022 – Spring 2024 **Graduate Assistant**, UConn Humanities Institute
Collaborated with researchers from a wide range of disciplines and backgrounds to organize talks and events, building a shared space for advancing work in the humanities.

Summer 2022 **Graduate Assistant**, Picturing the Pandemic Project, UConn Humanities Institute
Graduate Student Technician, College of Liberal Arts and Sciences (CLAS)

Fall 2021 – Spring 2022 **Research Assistant** for Faculty of Color Working Group (FOCWG)
Helped organize the annual FOCWG Conference, which brings faculty of color together to address the institutional challenges they face in academia and to support one another's professional and personal growth.

Spring 2020 – Present *Member* of the *Expression, Communication, and Origins of Meaning* Research Group (ECOM)

Teaching Experience

Spring 2026 **Graduate Certificate in College Instruction**, University of Connecticut.
Completed seminars on best teaching practices, course design, and student assessment. Developed strategies for engaging students, guiding discussion of controversial issues, and designing assignments that bring an ethos of play into the classroom while serving course learning objectives. Built a teaching portfolio and worked through course materials and classroom challenges alongside other college instructors.

Fall 2024 **Instructor of Record**, Phil 1104: Philosophy and Social Ethics

Spring 2021 **Teaching Assistant**, Phil 1104: Philosophy and Social Ethics

Fall 2020 **Teaching Assistant**, Phil 1106: Non-western and Comparative Philosophy

Spring 2020 **Teaching Assistant**, Phil 1104: Philosophy and Social Ethics

Fall 2019 **Teaching Assistant**, Phil 1104: Philosophy and Social Ethics

Spring 2014 – Spring 2017 Writing Tutor, Learning Center, Brooklyn College

Presentations, Events and Conferences

October 30, 2026 *"Minimal Mindreading: Mental States as Affordances,"* Presentation for the Philosophy of Animal Minds Group, National University of Córdoba

October 5–6, 2023 *"The Value of Pushmi-pullyu Representations for Understanding Animal Minds,"* Presentation at MillikanFest Conference, University of Connecticut

June 20–23, 2023 *"The Value of Pushmi-pullyu Representations for Understanding Animal Minds,"* Presentation at Society for Philosophy and Psychology (SPP) Conference, University of Pittsburgh

February 16, 2023 *"Pushmi-Pullyu Representations,"* Presentation at the Practical Mental Representations Workshop, Chapman University

February 11, 2023 *"Minimal Theory of Mind and Pushmi-Pullyu Representations,"* Presentation at New Work in the Theory of Mind Graduate Conference, University of Bucharest

July 19–22, 2022 *"A Pushmi-Pullyu Psychology,"* Presentation at 3rd Joint Conference of the Society for Philosophy and Psychology (SPP) and European Society for Philosophy and Psychology (ESPP), University of Milan

December 3, 2020 *"Minimal Theory of Mind – A Millikanian Approach,"* Presentation at Expression, Communication, and Origins of Meaning (ECOM) Research Group, University of Connecticut

Fall 2017 Wolfe Institute Fellowship Presentation at CUNY, Brooklyn College

Awards and Fellowships

Summer 2023 Millikan Fellowship

Summer 2022 Expression, Language, and Music (ELM) Fellowship

2020-2021 ECOM Research Group Fellowship (Summer and Fall 2020; Summer and Winter 2021)

Fall 2019 – Spring 2024 Harriott Fellowship Award, University of Connecticut Graduate School

Spring 2018 Stanley Malinovich Memorial Award for Excellence in Philosophy

Phi Sigma Tau Induction

Philosophy Departmental Honors Award

Spring 2017 Beth J. Singer Scholarship for Excellence in Philosophy

Fall 2014 – Spring 2018 New York State and New York City Council Merit Award Winner

United Federation of Teachers Scholarship for Academic Excellence

Service Work

Fall 2025 Reviewer, *Crítica*

Spring 2024 – Present Reviewer, *Synthese*

Spring 2023 – Fall 2023 MillikanFest, Organizing Committee

Spring 2023 National High School Ethics Bowl Judge

Fall 2022 Reviewer, *Biological Theory*

UConn Graduate School Orientation

Fall 2020 Institute for the Recruitment of Teachers Student Panelist

UConn Graduate School Orientation

Fall 2019 – Spring 2020 Minorities and Philosophy (MAP) University of Connecticut Chapter Team Member
Institute on Teaching and Mentoring Conference

Fall 2018 Organizer and Discussion Moderator, Session on Queer Philosophy, CUNY Philosophy Department

Fall 2017 – Winter 2020 Philosophy Department College Assistant, Brooklyn College, CUNY

Spring 2016 – Spring 2019 Minorities and Philosophy (MAP) Brooklyn College Chapter Leader and Event Organizer

References

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